

Guest Column >> **NASSER HUSSAIN**

Time for a Cull

Twenty20 is suited to India because it's a game of flair where you don't need to be overly fit. You just need to be talented, with a natural and raw ability.

I have always said India play better cricket when they play with passion and fire. India can't do things on a cricket field in the old-fashioned way, the quiet, Indian, easy-going way. By and large, Indians are friendly, happy-go-lucky people so it may come naturally to them, but for me, they don't play their best cricket like that anymore. They have to play with passion and fire. It's something Sourav Ganguly gave them in his captaincy and I've seen a lot more of that ability to scrap and fight in this Twenty20 side.

When Andrew Flintoff had a go at Yuvraj Singh, he gave it back to Flintoff by hitting six sixes off the next bowler. Back in England, someone tried to wind up Zaheer Khan through the jelly beans saga and Khan ended up being man of the series. When India visited Australia in 2001, Ganguly wasn't intimidated by Steve Waugh. Harbhajan Singh bowled them out and the Indian team fought back, down to the last man. That's what I mean by passion and fire.

It's difficult to keep that energy stoked all the time on a long tour, but in a T20 tournament lasting two weeks you can do that, especially with young players. It's amazing just what one or two changes can do. In the World T20, India had more than a few changes from the side that I saw playing ODIs against England, and it changed the complexion of the way they played. A team reflects the style and attitude of its captain and the Indian team is starting to reflect Mahendra Singh Dhoni a little bit, in an extravagant, outgoing manner. You saw it on the field all the time, in the

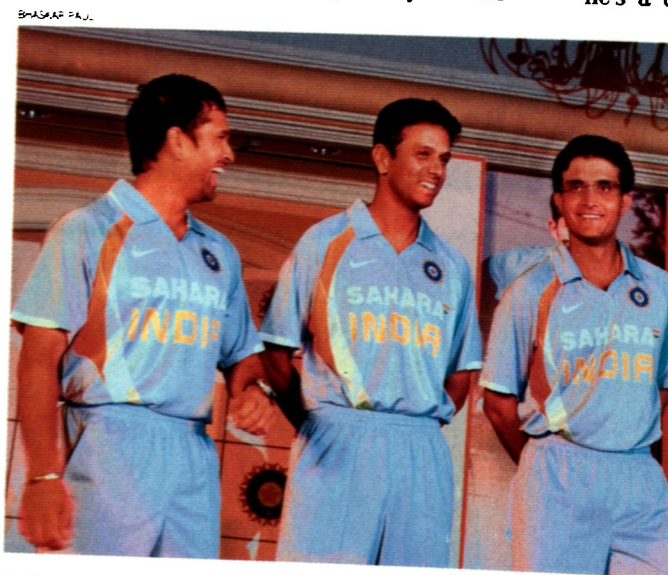
celebrations every time a wicket fell, in the support a bowler got even when getting caned.

Maybe it is the nature of Twenty20 cricket that brought out this quality in the Indians, as this is a highly-charged occasion. The way Yuvraj and Dhoni were batting was a massive plus for India. Being in Durban was a lucky bonus for them—South Africa felt they were playing away from home, Australia were away from home. As I **BIG THREE: Tendulkar, Dravid and Ganguly are not yet dispensable**

don't have natural ability. You only have to drive around Mumbai to see young lads play and realise that they are naturally gifted young cricketers. In India and in England, for some reason, they don't want to take advantage of that. I think Greg Chappell tried to inject youth in the team, trying to get in players like Suresh Raina and trying to move out guys like Ganguly. When India played the ODIs against England, I just kept hearing the same old names. Like, with all due respect, Ajit Agarkar; he's a decent cricketer but nothing

more. So I think they needed an injection of youth and they've got that in the World T20.

While at the T20, I got into a taxicab and the South African driver said that the one team that should be very good in the next decade is India. People here were used to the Tendulkars and the Dravids, but for the first time they saw just how well Yuvraj could really bat, what Rohit Sharma could do, how R.P. Singh swung the ball. There's a



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watched India strangle Australia, I thought, if they play the final on the same ground the next day, India would win without a problem.

Twenty20 is a game that is suited to India because it's a game of flair and it's a fairly simple game. When batting, you see the ball, you hit the ball. It's not a game where you need to be overly fit, you just need to be talented and you need natural, raw ability. And you can't tell me that Indian cricketers

lot for India to do, but it's an exciting time, it's an interesting time to be watching from the outside.

It is how India handles the gains from this event that will be revealing. The natural reaction is for people to say, get rid of all the senior players. I certainly wouldn't. You don't go from a whole bunch of old players to a whole bunch of young players. It just does not work. You look at any sport, you look at Manchester United, you look at any